

October 28, 2025

THE FUTURE OF LABOR: AI, INCENTIVES, AND THE END OF WORK AS WE KNOW IT

Jordi Visser

JVisser@22VResearch.com

22vresearch.com

Executive Summary

This report examines the structural transformation of the global labor market driven by artificial intelligence and why this shift represents both the most powerful deflationary force in modern history and the greatest challenge to capitalism's incentive system.

The analysis begins with Amazon's leaked internal plan to replace over 500,000 workers with robots, a signal that the debate over automation has moved from theory to execution. It explores how AI's second stage the agentic phase is now directly reshaping employment, corporate margins, and monetary policy.

The report argues that the traditional relationship between corporate profits and labor demand has broken down since the launch of ChatGPT. Earnings per share continue to climb even as job openings and temporary employment fall, revealing a historic decoupling between capital and labor. This divergence marks the emergence of a K-shaped economy in which asset owners prosper while wage earners face stagnation.

Drawing on insights from Marc Andreessen's "abundance thesis", the paper frames two potential futures one of deflationary abundance and one of disruptive dislocation and concludes that both dynamics are likely to coexist for years. The middle chapters dissect the corporate incentive structure that makes labor replacement inevitable ("show me the incentive and I'll show you the outcome"), linking executive compensation, quarterly earnings pressure, and shareholder demands to the acceleration of automation across industries.

A dedicated section on political and regulatory backlash highlights growing concern among policymakers, economists, and populist movements, outlining the likely policy tools from robot taxes to shortened workweeks that may emerge in response. Yet, as historical precedent suggests, the report concludes that market and geopolitical competition will overwhelm most restrictions, ensuring the automation trend persists.

Finally, the paper explains why this time is different: AI scales at software speed and, for the first time, automates not just physical tasks but cognitive work, soon extending to humanoid robotics. The closing section provides investment implications, emphasizing five principles for navigating the transition:

1. Favor capital-intensive firms with high automation potential.
2. Focus on infrastructure enablers, semiconductors, data centers, and energy systems.
3. Monitor regulatory risk by sector.
4. Track fiscal responses that reshape taxation and redistribution.
5. Prepare for sustained K-shaped outcomes across markets and geographies.

In sum, this report contends that AI is not merely another productivity tool but the defining macro driver of the next decade, one that will compress business cycles, challenge monetary policy, and redefine the relationship between labor, capital, and growth. Investors who grasp these dynamics early will navigate the coming disruption from a position of strength.

The Catalyst: Amazon's 500,000-Job Warning

Earlier this year, Torsten Slok of Apollo posted a chart showing that the Mag7 had not been hiring people since 2021. In recent videos, I have demonstrated how the historical correlation between S&P 500 stock prices and earnings per share versus payroll data has broken down since the launch of ChatGPT coinciding precisely with the Mag7's hiring freeze. Last week, a leaked internal document from Amazon revealed plans to replace more than 500,000 jobs with robots in the coming years, a shocking admission from one of the largest employers in the United States and a company whose workforce exceeds 1.5 million globally. Apparently that process is beginning now as a source revealed they would be laying off 30,000 people now.

Yet when economists, strategists and inflationistas discuss the weakness in the labor market, they tend to fall back on familiar explanations: immigration declines and the impact of higher interest rates. Given that much of my time is spent debating the widespread obsession, which seems to intensify with older people in the industry, over the supposed AI "bubble," this myopia doesn't surprise me. But as we stand on the threshold of stage two of AI, bubble or not, and as the Fed prepares another rate cut while the stock market continues climbing and nominal GDP remains near 5%, it's time for me to share my perspective on the labor market and how it is being directly reshaped by this next phase of artificial intelligence. Warning at this point to those obsessed with an AI bubble, if you are wrong on that obsession, it sets off a daisy chain of errors across all investments and forecasts as AI is driving everything macro. For investors and parents who are not using AI daily, the real question is whether ignoring AI now risks preparing your children for future competitiveness.

I define stage one of AI as the education phase, when AI memorizes everything we once needed to learn in school, effectively commoditizing education itself. Stage two is when they graduate and go to work and disrupt the labor markets. This year, that will manifest primarily in the form of AI agents or digital knowledge workers. But the physical world is not far behind. Last week, Tesla announced on their earnings call that they expect to remove the safety driver from their robotaxi fleet in Austin before the end of this year. For me, this represents the first graduation of workers in the physical world, a continuum that will extend from autonomous transportation to humanoid robots. This brings us back to the Amazon leak, reported by The New York Times. Earlier this year, Amazon had already announced, not leaked, that they had reached one million robot employees. Together, these milestones mark an inflection point in the debate over artificial intelligence and automation. This is no longer a theoretical discussion about whether AI will disrupt labor markets; it is a concrete, accelerating reality with profound implications for corporate profit margins, equity valuations, and the broader structure of the economy. For investors, the Amazon revelation should serve as a wake-up call: the incentives embedded in modern capitalism, particularly the relentless pressure on public companies to maximize shareholder returns, are driving a structural shift toward labor replacement at unprecedented speed and scale. As Charlie Munger famously said, "Show me the incentive and I will show you the outcome." The outcome here is clear: corporations driven by bottom-lines will replace human workers with machines whenever economically viable. But this transition carries significant risks beyond the balance sheet. Accelerating job displacement threatens to deepen income inequality, fueling political backlash and regulatory interventions that could reshape entire industries. Investors who fail to account for these dynamics, both the profit opportunities and the societal disruptions, risk being blindsided by one of the most consequential economic transformations of our time.

The Divergence: Profits Soar as Labor Weakens

For investors, this reality has already had a profound impact on monetary policy and the disruptions associated with the K-shaped divide between labor and asset owners. In August, Jerome Powell prepared the market for the Federal Reserve's pivot toward prioritizing labor market concerns over inflation risks, reflecting growing unease among policymakers about the health of the American workforce. The cries of "Policy Mistake!" echoed throughout X from inflation-focused commentators, many of them disguised permabears. Given that this came after sustained pressure from the Trump administration, the "Fed Independence Short the Dollar!" crowd also jumped into the fray.

The reality, based on the Fed's stated rationale, is that it has begun cutting rates in response to what Chair Powell has described as "softening" labor conditions. While the Fed has not explicitly linked this weakness to artificial intelligence, the concern is real and notable. Two former Fed chairs, Ben Bernanke and Janet Yellen, were among the prominent economists who signed a September 2025 letter urging the Department of Labor to improve data collection on AI's impact on employment, signaling that even veteran policymakers recognize something fundamental may be shifting. The data tells a striking story. Since the launch of ChatGPT in November 2022, two key labor market indicators—temporary employment and job openings, have declined sharply, even as S&P 500 earnings per share have surged to record highs. This is not a typical economic pattern. Historically, rising corporate profits correlate with strong labor demand; companies hire more workers to generate more revenue as their businesses expand. But today, we are witnessing a decoupling: capital owners are prospering while wage earners face a stagnating job market. This is the essence of a K-shaped economy, asset prices climb, enriching shareholders and those with equity exposure, while the median worker confronts diminished opportunities and wage growth that lags productivity gains. The implications for inequality are profound, and the political consequences may be swift. Yet this divergence may only be the beginning. So far, AI has largely functioned as a tool for optional human augmentation, making workers more productive rather than replacing them outright. But we are now entering the agentic era, in which digital employees can be "hired" at scale to perform tasks autonomously and work 24/7/365. My expectation is that 2026 will mark a turning point, as companies rapidly deploy AI agents across functions ranging from customer service to software development, accelerating the labor market divergence we have already begun to observe.

Andreessen's Abundance Thesis: Why Both Futures May Coexist

This topic of AI's impact on the jobs market is one area that I have spent a great deal of time on over the last year due mainly due to helping prepare my children. Parents have the experience of job disruptions, and this is where it is critical that parents don't just call this a bubble. Among the great list of voices debating AI's impact on employment, Marc Andreessen's view has been the one I lean towards the closest and in the end has a positive result but the path to those endings will create a lot of pain along the journey. It offers perhaps the most level-headed perspective. The debate typically frames the question in binary terms: will AI create new jobs to replace those it destroys, or will it lead to mass unemployment? Andreessen cuts through this false dichotomy with a simple economic argument: although he believes like all technologies, AI will create jobs we cannot think of today, if on the other hand, AI truly eliminates the need for human labor across the economy, the result will not be widespread poverty but rather hyper-deflation. In a world of abundant AI-driven productivity, goods and services that once cost hundreds of dollars would cost pennies. Everything, in essence, would become free or nearly free. Scarcity would give way to abundance. But I believe the reality is more complex than either/or. Both dynamics, job destruction and job creation, unemployment and abundance are likely to unfold simultaneously, creating a prolonged and uneven transition. The labor force participation rate in the United States has been declining for decades, a trend driven not solely by technology but by demographics, government transfer payments, entitlements, and the wealth effects of rising asset prices that allow certain segments of the population to opt out of work entirely. We are already living through a version of this story. An aging population is shrinking the available labor pool, creating shortages even as automation advances. Meanwhile, fiscal support and social safety nets have enabled millions to exit the workforce. At the same time, AI is generating new categories of employment, data center construction, semiconductor manufacturing, energy infrastructure to power computation, that will absorb some displaced workers. For investors, this means the path forward is not a clean replacement of old jobs with new ones, nor is it an immediate leap into a post-scarcity utopia. Instead, we should expect a multidecade period of economic dislocation, rising inequality, and sectoral volatility, eventually culminating in something closer to Andreessen's vision of material abundance. The question is not whether we reach that destination, but how disruptive the journey will be and which companies, industries, and asset classes will thrive or collapse along the way.

The Incentive Structure – Why Corporations Must Replace Labor

Charlie Munger's principle, "Show me the incentive and I will show you the outcome," provides the clearest lens through which to understand why corporate America will aggressively pursue labor replacement, regardless of the social consequences. As economist Joseph Schumpeter observed, "The very success of capitalism will create conditions that will make it impossible to maintain." We are now witnessing this dynamic in real time: capitalism's relentless drive for efficiency and profit maximization is generating technological capabilities that threaten to undermine the labor market upon which consumer capitalism has historically depended. Labor compensation represents approximately \$60 trillion of the roughly \$120 trillion global economy, making it by far the largest cost center in economic production. For publicly

traded companies operating under relentless pressure from shareholders to maximize earnings growth and return on equity, the incentive to reduce this cost is overwhelming. This is not a matter of corporate villainy; it is structural. CEOs and executives are compensated primarily through stock-based awards tied to share price performance. Quarterly earnings cycles demand continuous margin expansion. Competitors who automate faster gain cost advantages that force others to follow or face obsolescence. The result is a race to replace human workers with digital labor wherever technologically feasible. Consider the evidence from corporate communications to investors. Amazon's leaked document about replacing 500,000 workers is merely the most visible example. Salesforce openly markets its AI platform as a way for companies to reduce headcount. Artisan, an AI startup, advertises its product with the tagline "stop hiring humans." Autonomous trucking companies explicitly tell investors their technology solves the "problem" of rising driver wages and labor shortages. Major employers like Walmart, UnitedHealth Group, and JPMorgan Chase have discussed AI-driven workforce reductions in earnings calls, framing automation as a path to improved operating leverage. These are not isolated cases; they represent a systematic shift in how corporations view labor, not as an asset to develop, but as a cost to eliminate. For investors, the implications are straightforward: companies that successfully automate will experience significant margin expansion, driving earnings growth even in flat revenue environments. Firms that resist automation, whether due to regulatory constraints, labor union resistance, or managerial inertia, will see their competitive positions erode. The incentive structure of modern capitalism ensures that labor replacement will accelerate, and investors must position portfolios accordingly favoring capital-intensive businesses with high automation potential over those reliant on human labor arbitrage.

The Political and Regulatory Backlash: The Key Risk to the Thesis

While corporate incentives point inexorably toward automation, political and social forces will inevitably push back, creating the primary risk to the labor replacement thesis. The question is not whether backlash will occur, but how severe it will be and whether it can meaningfully slow the pace of transformation. The signs of resistance are already emerging. In September 2025, a coalition of prominent economists, including Nobel laureates Daron Acemoglu, Ben Bernanke, Simon Johnson, and Joseph Stiglitz, along with former Treasury Secretary Janet Yellen, signed a letter urging the Department of Labor to prioritize data collection on AI's labor market impacts. The letter's bipartisan composition and heavyweight signatories signal that even establishment figures recognize the scale of potential disruption and the need for policy responses. Senator Bernie Sanders went further, releasing a report warning that AI could eliminate up to 100 million American jobs within a decade and calling for aggressive interventions including a "robot tax" on companies that replace workers with automation, mandatory profit-sharing arrangements, a 32-hour workweek with no loss of pay, and dramatic expansion of union protections. While Sanders represents the progressive edge of the political spectrum, his concerns are shared across ideological lines, voters in both parties express anxiety about job security and economic inequality. The Trump administration has sent mixed signals, simultaneously appointing AI industry executives to key policy roles while also firing tens of thousands of federal workers in what critics describe as clearing the path for automation. Globally, governments face an acute dilemma: nations that resist automation risk falling behind economically and losing competitive advantage to countries that embrace it, yet nations that allow unchecked labor displacement risk social unrest, political instability, and the collapse of consumer demand that drives economic growth. For investors, regulatory risk is real and sector specific. Healthcare, where licensing requirements and patient preference for human interaction create barriers, may see slower automation despite technical feasibility. Trucking, where safety regulations and union strength remain significant, could face political resistance even as autonomous technology matures. Retail and customer service, with less organized labor and fewer regulatory protections, are more vulnerable to rapid automation. However, history suggests that attempts to ban or severely restrict technologies that provide overwhelming competitive advantages typically fail. The essay "The Future of AI is Already Written" argues persuasively that humanity has limited control over technological trajectory efforts to restrict encryption in the 1990s collapsed, attempts to prevent nuclear proliferation largely failed, and the printing press spread despite monarchical opposition. When a technology offers immediate, large-scale economic or strategic benefits, market forces and geopolitical competition overwhelm regulatory barriers. Political backlash will create volatility, generate sector-specific headwinds, and possibly slow the pace of deployment through taxation or mandated transition periods. But it is unlikely to prevent the fundamental shift toward labor automation. For investors, this means monitoring policy developments closely, recognizing that regulatory interventions will create both risks and opportunities, but maintaining conviction that the underlying trend toward AI-driven labor replacement remains structurally intact.

Why This Time Is Different: Speed and Humanoids

Skeptics of the labor displacement thesis often invoke historical precedent: technology has always created more jobs than it destroyed, they argue, pointing to the Industrial Revolution's displacement of agricultural workers, the rise of the automobile industry after horses became obsolete, and the creation of entire new sectors, highways, motels, suburban development, that emerged from mechanization. Each technological wave, the argument goes, initially appeared threatening but ultimately raised living standards and expanded employment opportunities. Why should AI be any different? The answer lies in two fundamental distinctions: the speed of deployment and the nature of the technology itself. Previous waves of automation were constrained by physical limitations. Building factories required years. Constructing railroads and highways took decades. Training workers in new skills demanded time. The economy had breathing room to adjust—displaced workers could retrain, new industries could emerge, and social structures could adapt gradually. AI operates on an entirely different timescale. Digital automation scales at the speed of software deployment. Once a task can be performed by an algorithm, that capability can be replicated millions of times instantly at near-zero marginal cost. As the "Situational Awareness" framework argues, AI capabilities are improving at an exponential rate, with model performance roughly doubling every few months across key benchmarks. The gap between "technology becomes possible" and "technology is deployed at scale" has collapsed from decades to months, and in some cases weeks. When GPT-4 was released, millions of users adopted it within days. When AI coding assistants became viable, they spread across the software industry in quarters, not years. This compression of the adoption cycle means labor markets lack the adjustment time that characterized previous technological transitions. Workers cannot retrain fast enough; educational institutions cannot adapt curricula rapidly enough; policy responses lag far behind the pace of change. The second critical difference is the nature of the technology: AI is not merely automating specific tasks but creating general-purpose substitutes for human cognitive labor, and ultimately, with humanoid robots, for human physical labor as well. Previous automation targeted narrow functions, mechanical looms replaced hand weaving, assembly lines replaced artisan manufacturing, ATMs replaced bank tellers for routine transactions. But humans adapted by moving into roles requiring judgment, creativity, and interpersonal skills. AI threatens to collapse this distinction. Large language models already demonstrate reasoning capabilities across domains. Autonomous agents can now perform entire job functions, not just assist humans, but replace them entirely. Companies like Artisan and others are marketing "digital employees" that handle customer service, sales development, and administrative tasks from end to end without human intervention. The room-cleaning analogy from the essay "The Future of AI is Already Written" captures the difference: augmenting a human worker with better tools, a more efficient vacuum, a robotic arm to lift heavy objects, remains constrained by human availability and working hours. But deploying fully autonomous robots that clean rooms without any human involvement is infinitely scalable. One company can manufacture 1,000 robots and deploy them simultaneously across 1,000 locations with no additional human labor required. Now extend this logic to its ultimate conclusion: humanoid robots. Unlike specialized industrial robots bolted to factory floors, humanoid robots are designed to operate in human environments, use human tools, and perform human tasks. Built in the form of humans but equipped with superior strength, endurance, and critically artificial intelligence that may soon exceed human cognitive capabilities across virtually all domains, humanoids represent a universal labor substitute. If a humanoid can drive a truck, stock shelves, prepare food, provide elder care, and perform surgery, all tasks that humans currently do, then in principle, there is no economic function that requires a human worker. This is not science fiction; companies including Tesla, Boston Dynamics, Figure AI, and others are already demonstrating functional prototypes. For investors, the implications are profound. The transition from augmentation to full automation will be faster than historical precedent suggests, and the scope will be broader than previous technological disruptions. Sectors that seem insulated today, those requiring physical presence, manual dexterity, or human judgment, may be vulnerable within years, not decades. The timeline for capital allocation decisions has been compressed dramatically, and the winners will be those who recognize and position for this acceleration ahead of the market consensus.

Investment Implications: Navigating the Labor Paradox

I believe we are on a path toward Marc Andreessen's world of material abundance, a future in which AI-driven productivity makes goods and services so cheap that scarcity, in the traditional economic sense, largely disappears. But the transition to that destination will be turbulent, uneven, and politically fraught, creating both extraordinary opportunities and significant risks for investors. The paradox at the heart of this transformation is that AI promises to deliver the greatest prosperity in human history while simultaneously creating the most severe social dislocation modern economies have experienced. For those building investment portfolios, this tension must inform every decision. The correlation breaks I referenced at the outset, S&P 500 earnings per share surging even as temporary employment and job openings decline sharply since the November 2022 launch of ChatGPT, are not anomalies or temporary divergences. They are early indicators of a structural shift in how economic value is created and distributed. Corporate profits are decoupling from

labor demand because companies are learning to generate revenue and earnings growth without proportional increases in headcount. In some cases, they are achieving growth while reducing headcount. This trend will accelerate as agentic AI and automation technologies mature, leading to sustained margin expansion for companies that successfully implement these tools. For investors, this suggests several guiding principles. First, favor companies with high operating leverage and capital intensity over those dependent on labor arbitrage. Businesses that can scale revenue without adding workers proportionally, software, cloud services, semiconductors, energy infrastructure, logistics networks with high automation potential will see expanding margins and valuation multiples. Conversely, firms relying on human labor for value creation, particularly in roles vulnerable to automation such as customer service, back-office operations, entry-level professional services, and routine manufacturing, face structural margin compression and increased competition from AI-native entrants. Second, infrastructure plays, data centers, semiconductor manufacturing, energy generation and transmission, and specialized computing hardware represent the “picks and shovels” of the AI revolution and will likely outperform and see hiring as the buildout of AI capabilities continues. These sectors benefit from sustained capital investment regardless of which specific AI applications succeed, providing exposure to the trend while diversifying away from winner-take-all risks in the application layer. Third, monitor regulatory and political risk closely, particularly in labor-intensive sectors. Healthcare, transportation, and financial services face significant potential for government intervention, whether through taxation of automation, mandatory transition periods, licensing restrictions, or requirements for human oversight. These interventions may not prevent automation but will affect the pace and profitability of deployment, creating volatility and differentiating winners from losers within sectors. Fourth, recognize that government responses to labor displacement, whether universal basic income experiments, shifts in tax policy from labor to capital, expanded social safety nets, or sector-specific protections will create both risks and opportunities. Policies designed to redistribute gains from automation may pressure corporate margins but could also stabilize consumer demand and prevent the deflationary spiral that would result from collapsing purchasing power. Infrastructure spending to support displaced workers, expanded education and training programs, and incentives for domestic manufacturing could create new investment opportunities even as traditional employment contracts. Fifth, prepare for a prolonged period of K-shaped economic outcomes in which asset owners and capital continue to capture disproportionate gains from productivity growth while labor’s share of national income continues to shrink. This has profound implications for consumer-facing businesses: luxury goods, travel, and premium services may thrive as wealth concentrates, while mass-market retailers and middle-tier service providers face demand compression. Geographic disparities will also intensify, with technology hubs and capital-rich regions prospering while manufacturing-dependent and rural areas struggle, affecting everything from real estate valuations to municipal bond creditworthiness. The ultimate question for investors is not whether we are heading toward a world of abundance, but how to preserve and grow capital during the chaotic transition that will unfold over the next decade and beyond. The future may indeed be one of material plenty, as Andreessen mentions, where the cost of goods and services falls toward zero and scarcity ceases to constrain human welfare. But the path to that future will test every assumption about how value is created, distributed, and preserved. Traditional financial analysis focused on revenue growth, market share, and competitive positioning must now incorporate assessments of automation potential, regulatory exposure, and resilience to labor market disruptions. Understanding the incentive structures driving corporate behavior, the compressed timeline for technological deployment, and the political forces that will attempt to slow or redirect this transformation will be as important as balance sheet analysis and discounted cash flow models. For those who navigate this transition successfully, the rewards will be substantial. For those who cling to outdated models of how economies function and how value is generated, the consequences will be severe. The divergence between corporate earnings and labor market health is not a puzzle to be solved or an aberration to be corrected, it is the new reality, and it is only beginning.

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